

states BIHAR

Flood victims who just about managed to escape death now face an uphill battle against disease and deprivation

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Even as he faked calmness, Dr Shakeel-ur Rahman was in turmoil as he tried to save a two-year-old girl suffering from acute diarrhoea. He needed to put her on intravenous therapy but the doctor and his staff could not locate her veins. With time running short, he gave up, moving the kid to an ambulance to Raghupur Referral Hospital, an apology of a hospital with only six beds, where scores of patients are still lying on the barren floor. He moved on to the next patient in the queue at the Belhi Relief Camp that has more than 50,000 occupants at the moment in the Bihar's flood-stricken Supaul district. "The number of patients, especially those suffering from dysentery with abdominal cramps, is too much. The magnitude is more than we can handle," he says.

The receding Kosi waters—the discharge was 70,000 cusec on September 16, down from over 1.5 lakh cusec during the floods in August—have posed an epidemic threat to the displaced villagers. Despite the river maintaining a receding trend, the Bihar authorities cannot relax because it is known to swell to peak by October. In fact, on October 5, 1968, Kosi played havoc as nine lakh cusec of water was discharged in one day alone. Forty years later, nobody has forgotten it.

Meanwhile, the Bihar Government has locked horns with the Centre over insufficient relief after the Union Home Ministry said the Rs 1,000-crore grant provided—following Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's visit to the state on August 29—was to repair the breach and strengthen the embankment. The Government, however, is using money for the rescue operations. Bihar officials argue that it was only about a 10th of what the state Government actually requires for the unparalleled rebuilding and rehabilitation exercise. Chief Minister Nitish Kumar met Singh in Delhi recently seeking fresh assistance of Rs 8,922 crore under a Kosi Special Package to meet the daunting challenges of rehabilitation.



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Kumar also met Nepal Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal, seeking his cooperation on turning the course of the river. The Nepalese premier is believed to have suggested setting up of hydel power projects to control discharge of water.

In the meantime, the flood waters accumulated for over three weeks—coupled with the fact that it contains floating human bodies and carcasses—have become just the ideal breeding ground for a number of water-borne diseases in five districts of Bihar. Already, more than 200 cases of diarrhoea have been reported from different relief camps and hospitals of Supaul, Araria, Madhepura and Saharsa. The Government has admitted to only four diarrhoeal deaths, but social workers and locals believe the toll could be higher.

Besides diarrhoeal deaths, pregnant women who managed to reach safe lands are now left to fend for themselves without even the basic antenatal care. Dr Rahman concedes the fact that many government medical units in Bihar's flood-affected zones like Raghupur Referral Hospital do not have trained people to apply anaesthetic substances. About 616 doctors have been deputed to the affected districts and many of them are operating from 242 medical camps. A special grant will be given to every flood-affected mother giving birth in relief camps (Rs 10,000 for male child and Rs 11,000 for girl child).

Life has also changed drastically for lakhs of people. Many daily-wage earners are heading to Haryana and Punjab because employment opportunities back home seem to be over for ever. In

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN



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